

Chapter 40-1

The actors who came for auditions would be divided into groups to enter the audition room.

Each group had two to three people.

Unfortunately, Liang Shi and Chen Liuying were assigned to the same group.

Even though she felt disdain for Chen Liuying in her heart, Liang Shi didn't show it on the surface. When she saw Chen Liuying and Bai Weiwei, she even nodded slightly as a greeting.

But Chen Liuying snorted lightly and rolled her eyes, while Bai Weiwei acted as if she hadn't seen anything.

Liang Shi: "..."

She felt that with Chen Liuying's personality, she would truly be cannon fodder¹ in the entertainment industry.

However, Liang Shi didn't take this to heart.

They were strangers to begin with.

This production crew had high standards. Even for auditions, they borrowed the stage of Qingcheng Grand Theater, and the audition venue was on the stage itself.

Generally speaking, stage plays were much more difficult than filming in a crew.

Not only would the audience give feedback on the spot, but there were also simple props, lines and actions that couldn't go wrong, positioning errors that weren't allowed—unlike filming in a crew where they could call "cut" again and again.

But when Liang Shi and the others came to audition, it wouldn't be as strict as an actual stage play.

They just had to perform on stage while a row of people sat below seriously watching, which was still quite stressful.

Especially since this row of people were all industry bigwigs.

After Liang Shi entered, she saw Zhao Ying sitting beside the director. Zhao Ying's gaze also looked over, and Liang Shi smiled and nodded as a greeting.

Incidentally, she also saw the woman who had been wearing casual clothes outside earlier. She was sitting at the edge of the second row, not next to Zhao Ying, not with anyone else, sitting alone by herself. She had now taken off her hat and let her long hair fall loose, strikingly beautiful in an aggressive way.

Liang Shi only glanced once before looking away.

Mainly because she had just looked up the name Yang Shuyan outside, and the accompanying tags were "Best Actress," "Child Star," "Imperial Alpha²," and "Acting Dynasty."

In comparison, what surprised her more was that Zhao Ying was actually an Omega.

Unlike Chen Liuying, Liang Shi came alone and, based on previous experience, went on stage by herself.

Meanwhile, Bai Weiwei instructed Chen Liuying from below the stage, telling her to take it slow and show her true abilities, until the director became impatient and frowned, asking, "Are you going to perform or not? If not, call the next one."

Only then did Bai Weiwei respond: "Coming."

Chen Liuying unhurriedly went on stage.

The audition segment was designated by the director. She and Chen Liuying would perform for each other, acting out the same segment.

The director had designated exactly the segment that Liang Shi had practiced with Xu Qingzhu last night.

Actually, it wasn't really Liang Shi's good luck.

Any actor who had read the script thoroughly could tell at a glance where the climax of this script was, where the plot that could best demonstrate an actor's layered acting skills was located.

Since she and Chen Liuying were strong competitors for this role, they would definitely be asked to perform the key scenes.

Liang Shi had made complete preparations, so naturally she wasn't afraid at this moment.

However, there was a disagreement about who should go first.

According to the numbers, Liang Shi should go first.

But Chen Liuying requested to perform first.

After asking for Liang Shi's opinion, the director agreed to the switch.

Liang Shi didn't mind either way. Performing first or last was the same to her; she didn't quite understand what Chen Liuying's intention was.

However, she professionally supported Chen Liuying's performance.

The supporting role should be the female lead, which was the character Zhao Ying was about to play.

As the resilient and strong female character in the drama, who valued relationships and took responsibility, she discovered she had been betrayed by someone she trusted completely. After being betrayed, she quickly adjusted her state and began to counterattack.

This scene was the confrontation after the counterattack.

A very long passage of dialogue.

The director also asked: "Miss Liang, do you need the script? You can bring it."

"No need, thank you." Liang Shi politely declined.

"You remember it?" The director was surprised.

You should know that there hadn't been a single actor before who could remember the other person's lines.

Wasn't she just showing off?

"My script doesn't allow for changed lines," the director's tone became somewhat stern. "If you deliberately use this method to cause your partner to make mistakes, no matter how well you perform, I won't use you."

Liang Shi smiled slightly, "Please rest assured, I won't do that."

After saying this, she paused and said seriously and reverently: "Acting requires mutual achievement."

The director was stunned for two seconds. He neither praised nor criticized, but simply said: "Begin."

Footnotes:

¹ **Cannon fodder:** A term from Chinese web novels referring to a minor character destined to fail or die, typically used to advance the main characters' story.

² **Imperial Alpha:** A term from ABO (Alpha-Beta-Omega) dynamics referring to an extremely dominant and powerful Alpha character, often used to describe top-tier Alphas in the hierarchy.

Chapter 40-2

The first line was Liang Shi's.

Liang Shi closed her eyes, and when she opened them again, she had adjusted her state. As soon as she spoke, she was completely different from before—with clear and resonant broadcasting diction¹, rich emotion, and very appropriate facial expressions, though one could tell she was slightly nervous.

She spoke three lines before it was Chen Liuying's turn.

Chen Liuying directly adopted an aggressive acting approach, grabbing Liang Shi's collar right from the start with a fierce and menacing appearance that frightened quite a few people, and also slightly startled Liang Shi.

But in just a moment, Liang Shi came back to her senses and confronted her.

...

This scene quickly ended.

Chen Liuying had adopted an unexpected but reasonable acting method. Her bold and dramatic emotions made everyone present feel her anger and despair.

It should be a performance worthy of 7 points.

Even Liang Shi, who was her opponent, felt that her improvement was significant, much better than when she performed in the crew some time ago.

Perhaps some people were naturally suited for villain roles.

After Chen Liuying finished performing, seeing the flash of amazement in the director's eyes, she was triumphant and confident as she looked at Liang Shi with some provocation.

Liang Shi ignored her provocation. Having gotten too deeply into the female lead's character just now, she was having trouble getting out of character. She was quickly adjusting her state to help herself exit the role.

It was also at this time that she understood Chen Liuying's intention.

Supporting someone else's performance didn't require being too emotionally invested, so it could be placed later.

Her powerful explosive performance earlier could create psychological pressure on her opponent. Under her strong impact, any actor who understood acting would be involuntarily drawn into character, and then getting out of character to perform the part they were auditioning for would definitely compromise their state significantly.

Who knows who gave Chen Liuying this advice.

It could be said that her wishful thinking was crackling away, calculating both psychological and physical aspects.

Liang Shi was desperately taking deep breaths at the side of the stage, while the director below was already urging, "Miss Liang, are you ready? Time is limited, just say something when you're ready."

Liang Shi gestured an OK sign toward the audience below.

Then she walked back to center stage, looking like she wasn't in good condition, even appearing somewhat frail.

She didn't look at all like someone who could play a villain.

Chen Liuying, who was supporting her performance, held the script and continued to read lines in the same manner as before, making it easy for people to be misled into character.

All psychological tactics.

Liang Shi couldn't help but laugh.

It had been a long time since she'd seen such boring tactics.

After Chen Liuying finished reading her lines, it perfectly connected with Liang Shi's disdainful laugh.

The smile spread from the corner of her mouth to her eyes. Those bright eyes stared straight at Chen Liuying, then she shrugged contemptuously: "Winners and losers need no further words."

The tone in which she delivered this line was completely different from before.

Dejected, low-spirited, with a touch of disdain.

She completely interpreted the deep meaning of this line.

Her clear and resonant broadcasting diction carried a hint of sobbing, yet still maintained the pride of a wealthy young lady.

Just this one line made everyone below gasp in amazement.

This... this was the character herself!

Walking out from the drama.

Zhao Ying watched the reactions of the director and Yang Shuyan with interest.

The director's eyes were now bright, as if he had found gold.

Yang Shuyan nodded slightly, acknowledging Liang Shi's acting skills.

The performance on stage continued. Liang Shi became increasingly calm and composed, her eyes reddening, but it didn't affect her delivery of lines at all.

When she smiled and then sang that line "Life is naturally full of endless regret like flowing water to the east"² in a melodious operatic voice, the director was already so excited he wanted to slam the table, but was held down by Zhao Ying at the crucial moment.

The director's eyes widened as he excitedly mouthed: "Yes, yes, yes! Exactly!"

Only she understood this line!

Only she sang it!

And it was melancholy and lingering, with countless turns and twists, sung so heartbreakingly!

Zhao Ying smiled with satisfaction, as if saying—how could the person I recommended be wrong?

...

When Liang Shi finished performing, she collapsed exhaustedly on the stage.

She closed her eyes, as if her life had also ended along with the character.

There was a brief silence in the venue.

Everyone held their breath, afraid of disturbing the person who was sleeping on stage.

There was reluctance about her departure, sadness, and even Omegas with low tear thresholds were already teary-eyed.

A few seconds later, it was the director who first stood up and applauded with red-rimmed eyes.

Then thunderous applause followed.

Footnotes:

¹ **Broadcasting diction:** Refers to the clear, precise pronunciation and speech patterns used by professional radio and television announcers in China, characterized by perfect articulation and proper tone.

² **"Life is naturally full of endless regret like flowing water to the east":** This is a reference to a famous line from classical Chinese poetry, specifically from Li Yu's (李煜) poem "Waves Washing Sand" (浪淘沙). The original line is "自是人生長恨水長東" and expresses the sentiment that life is inherently filled with endless sorrow and regret, like water that flows continuously eastward. It's often used to convey deep melancholy and the inevitability of loss and disappointment in life.

Chapter 40-3

//

When Liang Shi came out of the audition room, quite a few people gathered around to watch.

Those with more courage asked, "What happened in there? Why was the applause so loud?"

Liang Shi had returned to her gentle state, "Just a normal audition."

Meanwhile, the director inside was watching the next group's performance with an expression that clearly read four words—utterly boring.

Liang Shi and Chen Liuying had auditioned together, so naturally they came out together as well.

When they reached downstairs and were about to part ways, Liang Shi heard Chen Liuying say disdainfully, "Hypocrite."

Liang Shi's gaze looked over, catching a fixed point from the ethereal void, then she laughed lightly: "That's still better than playing dirty tricks in the shadows."

Chen Liuying: "..."

She immediately flew into a rage, "Who the fuck are you talking about?"

"Did I mention you? Why are you so angry?" Liang Shi still wore a smile, her voice calm. "Miss Chen, I sincerely wish you that your future stardom will be as upright and bright as your character."

The words "upright and bright" were clearly meant as a blessing.

But coming from Liang Shi's mouth, combined with Chen Liuying's behavior just now, the implied meaning was extremely heavy.

Chen Liuying sneered, "Liang Shi, what do you mean?"

Liang Shi: "Blessing you."

Chen Liuying: "..."

Seeing passersby casting glances their way.

Liang Shi was currently a nobody, so she had nothing to fear.

But Chen Liuying had already debuted and was afraid of being photographed. Bai Weiwei immediately tugged at Chen Liuying's arm, "Let's go."

Chen Liuying frowned and glanced down at her, "You're just afraid that Xu Qingzhu will cause you trouble, right?"

"No." Bai Weiwei said in a low voice, "People are watching."

"Then let them watch." Chen Liuying said impatiently, "Don't I even have the freedom to go on the streets anymore?"

Bai Weiwei: "..."

She pursed her lips and frowned, feeling that Chen Liuying's temper was getting worse and worse.

She was too lazy to coax her, and directly opened the car door by herself, "Whatever, get in if you want."

When Chen Liuying looked back at the previous location, Liang Shi had already disappeared.

Chen Liuying got into the nanny car¹ with a belly full of anger, and the car drove away from this street.

Neither person in the car spoke for a while.

After a moment, Chen Liuying finally laughed lightly, "Bai Weiwei, did you watch Xu Qingzhu's livestream today?"

Bai Weiwei bit her lip, "How could I watch? I came with you to the audition."

"I watched it." Chen Liuying relaxed her body, leaning against the back seat, "Setting everything else aside, Xu Qingzhu is really quite beautiful."

"You like her?" Bai Weiwei immediately became alert.

Chen Liuying denied it, "How could I?"

As she spoke, she pulled Bai Weiwei's hand and directly drew her into her embrace, her hand already restlessly settling on her waist, sliding under the hem of her clothes like a fish.

"Don't move." Bai Weiwei pressed down on her hand, "You haven't explained clearly yet."

Chen Liuying smiled roguishly, "I already said how could I? Weiwei."

She moved close to Bai Weiwei's ear, "I already said the person I love most is you. But what about you? Do you feel accomplished watching me get bullied?"

"No." Bai Weiwei couldn't restrain her wandering hands, her body gradually softening in her embrace like melting water, even her voice taking on a seductive tone, "How could I watch you get bullied?"

"No? Don't you think I don't have as much money and power as Liang Shi, so you don't like me anymore?" Chen Liuying knew exactly what her weak points were, looking at her with a mischievous expression as she became confused and emotional, "But Weiwei, the person who loves you most is me."

"I didn't." Bai Weiwei still retained a trace of reason, defending herself: "If I cared about power and status, how could I be with you?"

Chen Liuying's expression changed, and she said disdainfully: "You finally told the truth."

Extremely suppressed muffled sounds suddenly rang out in the car.

Even the driver couldn't help but frown.

Who would...

Forget it.

Play deaf.

Footnotes:

¹ **Nanny car:** A term commonly used in the Chinese entertainment industry to refer to luxury vehicles (usually vans or SUVs) used to transport celebrities and their entourage, similar to what might be called a "celebrity transport vehicle" in English.

Chapter 40-4

//

After finishing her audition, Liang Shi rewarded herself by going to eat fast food.

Normally she ate low-oil and low-salt foods, and fast food restaurants were places she almost never set foot in.

She would only come once when she was particularly happy or unhappy.

As soon as she walked into the fast food restaurant, she received a message from Zhou Li: [Hello? Are you done with your audition?]

Liang Shi replied instantly: [Yes, what's wrong, Sister Li?]

Zhou Li sent a voice message: "There's something urgent at the company, so I might have to work late. Could you please pick up Rainbow? You know her kindergarten. Usually she would stay with the teacher for a while, but since it's Friday today, parents have to pick up their children, so I'm troubling you. I'll treat you to a meal another day. After you pick her up, you can take her to my home, or just find a fast food restaurant to keep her at."

This was said as if Rainbow were an object.

Liang Shi asked: "Do I need to take her to the company?"

Zhou Li: "No need, if you come you'd have to work overtime. Consider today as external work."

Liang Shi: "..."

She accepted Zhou Li's kindness and sent her a message: [Okay, I'll go pick her up.]

So she made a detour to Rainbow's kindergarten.

When Liang Shi went to pick up Rainbow, the teacher asked: "Do you know this sister?"

"Mm." Rainbow maintained that aloof demeanor, "She's my mom's colleague."

After looking her over, the teacher called Zhou Li to confirm before releasing the child.

As soon as Liang Shi picked up Rainbow, she crouched down and asked in a low voice: "Which one is Su Yu?"

She still remembered the matter of coming to find Qi Jiao last time and returning empty-handed.

Although Qi Jiao had denied that Su Yu's mother was Su Yao, Liang Shi felt she might find new clues from Rainbow.

"There, that one." Rainbow pointed to a little girl in a pink princess dress not far away: "She's picked up by their family's butler."

Liang Shi looked over and saw a black nanny car¹.

It should be quite valuable.

However, all the children who could attend this place were either rich or noble. Although Liang Shi had never asked, she felt that Rainbow's father must be quite something.

Soon, that nanny car drove away, and Liang Shi felt somewhat disappointed.

"Don't her parents ever pick her up?" Liang Shi asked again.

Rainbow answered arrogantly: "I don't observe who picks her up every day, how would I know?"

Liang Shi: "...Okay."

As soon as she finished speaking, a crisp voice rang out: "Auntie!"

Liang Shi turned around and saw Ling Dang running over like the wind, while Sun Meirou stood smiling in the distance.

Afraid that Ling Dang would fall, Liang Shi immediately opened her arms to catch her.

Ling Dang laughed gleefully, but immediately started complaining: "I told Mom it was you, but Mom didn't believe me!"

"It seems our Ling Dang has good eyes after all." Liang Shi touched her head, "You also go to school at this kindergarten?"

"Yes!" Ling Dang was puzzled, "Weren't you here to find me?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She coughed lightly and pulled Rainbow over, "I came to help a colleague pick up a child, she's called..."

Before she could finish speaking, Ling Dang answered first: "I know, Zhou Caihong²."

"You know each other?" Liang Shi was shocked.

Ling Dang snorted lightly, "She made Shen Yiran cry last time."

Liang Shi: "..."

She hadn't intended to become a mediator for children, but Ling Dang insisted on following her and said she wanted to sleep with her tonight.

Sun Meirou tried to persuade her for a long time to no avail. Ling Dang was already on the verge of tears, pouting as she asked: "Auntie, don't you like me anymore?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She really couldn't withstand this kind of adorable child attack and immediately agreed.

Sun Meirou smiled apologetically at her: "Sorry for the trouble, Third Sister."

"It's nothing, it's what I should do." Liang Shi said: "I'll send her back after she's done playing."

After saying goodbye to Sun Meirou, Liang Shi took the two children to the fast food restaurant.

Ling Dang was so happy her eyes disappeared.

Ling Dang was quite well-behaved. Even though she had a "feud" with Rainbow, she didn't actively provoke her, at most giving Rainbow cold looks when facing her.

Liang Shi pretended not to see.

While busy taking care of the two children, she didn't forget to open Minghui Jewelry's livestream, only to find that the livestream had already ended.

When she opened Weibo³, she found that Minghui Jewelry was actually trending.

...?

Minghui would actually spend money to buy trending topics?

Looking more carefully, she found there were quite a few trending hashtags, mostly hanging on the latest searches, including hashtags like #Wealthy Young Lady's Temperament# #As Expected It Has To Be Someone From The Sheng Family# #Would Xu Qingzhu Consider Acting# #Minghui Jewelry Didn't Disappoint This Year# #Dream Autumn Series Is So Beautiful#.

All positive hashtags.

Footnotes:

¹ **Nanny car:** A term commonly used in the Chinese entertainment industry to refer to luxury vehicles (usually vans or SUVs) used to transport celebrities and their entourage.

² **Zhou Caihong:** This is Rainbow's Chinese name. "Caihong" (彩虹) literally means "rainbow" in Chinese.

³ **Weibo:** China's equivalent of Twitter, a popular social media microblogging platform.

Chapter 40-5

Liang Shi ate while scrolling through comments.

[What kind of heaven-defying script does Xu Qingzhu have! Academic genius! Universe-level divine beauty! Elite!]

[Compared to this, I'm like someone sent from heaven to make up the numbers.]

[Her temperament is really too outstanding, wuwuwu¹, sister please kill me.]

[I'll speak plainly, I want to sleep with her. doge²]

[Sigh, who doesn't want to?]

[...]

Xu Qingzhu had very high discussion levels online, mainly because of several beautiful animated GIFs that had circulated.

One was of her smiling with curved lips, another was of her tucking her hair behind her ear.

Netizens were calling out to film and television companies.

[Can all workplace dramas from now on please roll up to this standard?]

[Hey, can someone sign her to act? My Alpha DNA is stirring.]

[Also, my CP-shipping³ DNA is stirring. Does anyone else think her temperament mysteriously matches Yang Shuyan?]

[Heaven-conquering earth-conquering cool sister big villain Alpha X wealthy family princess bright and beautiful white-lotus-turned-dark⁴ Omega!!!]

[I can do this, sisters do you have videos?!]

[I have pictures!]

[...]

Liang Shi was like a little animal in a melon field⁵, following the clues given by netizens to trace the vine and find the melon, eventually reaching that Weibo post.

There was a picture edited by a blogger.

Yang Shuyan wearing a black and gold evening gown stood in the corner, while Xu Qingzhu had a face full of smiles, but her eyes were completely cold.

Imagining it in one's mind didn't seem that compatible, but when this picture with excellent atmosphere came out, netizens all transformed into CP-shipping machines.

[Let me ship them! I can do this!]

[Even though Miss Xu hasn't entered the entertainment industry yet, I'm already imagining what dramas she'll film.]

[Really begging, which company can poach her to act, I'll kneel in thanks.]

[...]

[For a moment I don't know if you're joking or serious. She's at least the legal heir of a company, why would a female boss stop being a boss to become a female celebrity? That would be crazy.]

[Friendly reminder, this person is married.]

[Another friendly reminder, Yang Shuyan's fans will arrive at the battlefield in three seconds, everyone save yourselves.]

[...]

Liang Shi vigorously liked that "married" comment.

Looking at that edited picture, she clicked report.

How could they put Xu Qingzhu and Yang Shuyan together?!

They clearly don't match at all!

Xu Qingzhu's official Alpha hasn't appeared yet!

The rumored elite returnee⁶, fluent in ten languages, with outstanding temperament, gentle and kind, filial and family-loving, emotionally devoted Lu Jiayi.

But now... the storyline had already deviated a little bit.

Would this official Alpha still appear?

Or would she only appear after she and Xu Qingzhu divorced?

"Rather than worrying about these meaningless questions, why not worry about your additional task?" The system's eerie voice suddenly rang in her mind, startling Liang Shi.

She rolled her eyes, "Why do you appear and disappear like a ghost?!"

"I'm here to remind you that your additional task has 56 hours left before expiring. Please pay attention to the task deadline. PS: Procrastination is the most annoying thing. Another PS: If you don't complete the task because of procrastination, that would be even more annoying." The system's eerie mechanical voice made Liang Shi feel numb, and she answered: "Okay, I'll do it tomorrow."

System: "I'm mainly worried about you, host. Your misfortune value has accumulated to 7, just a little bit more and it will trigger a level-one punishment."

Liang Shi: "..."

When did she offend Xu Qingzhu again?!

She perfunctorily dealt with the system and continued playing with the two children for a while.

When sending Rainbow home, it started raining outside again.

Under the dim yellow lights, fine rain threads were entangled, and raindrops danced aimlessly in the air.

Grooves kept winding across the car windows, and the windshield wipers worked diligently.

There was only one umbrella in the car. Liang Shi let Ling Dang stay in the car and walked Rainbow home under the umbrella before coming back down.

Originally she wanted to drive straight home, but when passing Jiangyu Road, she changed direction and drove to Xu Qingzhu's company.

Ling Dang sat in the car playing on her iPad, watching that dark-themed cartoon "Don't Cry, Rabbit" with great interest.

Liang Shi called Xu Qingzhu, but no one answered.

Given this person's previous habit of forgetting to charge her phone and having it turned off frequently, she called Lin Luoxi instead.

Lin Luoxi didn't answer either.

But shortly after, Xu Qingzhu called back.

"Are you still at the company?" Liang Shi asked.

The background noise on Xu Qingzhu's end was noisy, and it took a while before it became slightly quieter, "At a restaurant, everyone came out for a celebration banquet."

Liang Shi asked: "Have you been drinking?"

Xu Qingzhu suddenly laughed lightly, her voice casual and lazy, "Mm, had a little."

"Is it almost over?" Liang Shi asked again.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Almost, are you home?"

"On my way home." Liang Shi said: "Send me the address, I'll come pick you up."

"No need, you go back." Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll call a designated driver⁷ in a bit."

"It's too late, it's not safe." Liang Shi insisted, "Send me the location, I'll pick you all up."

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu compromised, "Alright."

Liang Shi stared at the location and turned at the next intersection.

Footnotes:

- ¹ **wuwuwu:** An onomatopoeia for crying sounds, commonly used in Chinese internet slang to express being moved to tears or overwhelming emotions.
- ² **doge:** An internet meme featuring a Shiba Inu dog, often used to indicate joking or playful intent in online comments.
- ³ **CP-shipping:** "CP" stands for "couple" and refers to fans pairing up characters or real people romantically. "Shipping" means supporting a romantic relationship between two characters.
- ⁴ **White-lotus-turned-dark:** A character archetype in Chinese web novels. A "white lotus" appears pure and innocent on the surface, while "turned dark" means they reveal a manipulative or evil nature underneath.
- ⁵ **Little animal in a melon field:** A reference to the Chinese idiom about a little animal (獐) that steals melons, used here metaphorically to describe someone following clues to dig up gossip.
- ⁶ **Elite returnee:** Refers to someone who studied abroad (usually in prestigious Western universities) and returned to China, often considered highly accomplished and westernized.
- ⁷ **Designated driver:** A service common in China where a professional driver is called to drive someone home in their own car when they've been drinking, rather than using a taxi or ride-sharing service.

Chapter 40-6

//

Liang Shi arrived at the restaurant downstairs. She didn't go up, but directly sent Xu Qingzhu a message: [I'm downstairs, call me when you're done.]

Xu Qingzhu replied instantly: [We're done.]

Not long after, a group of people came out in a grand procession.

Sally had drunk quite a lot and could barely walk steadily, clinging to Lin Luoxi like a little puppy.

Lin Luoxi looked like she hadn't drunk much and was still relatively sober.

Xu Qingzhu had her suit jacket draped over her arm, aloof and dignified. Liang Shi got out of the car with an umbrella, and as soon as she looked up, her eyes met Xu Qingzhu's across the rain-filled sky.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly curved her lips, her eyes full of smiles.

She raised her arm and waved in Liang Shi's direction.

Liang Shi said: "Stand there and don't move."

Xu Qingzhu nodded and obediently replied: "Okay."

Liang Shi walked over with the umbrella.

Watching this, Sally's alcohol suddenly sobered up halfway, "Why does it feel like they're filming an idol drama¹? OMG."

Lin Luoxi said disdainfully: "Look at your unsophisticated appearance."

Zhou Yi'an, who had just come out, was standing at the entrance trying to light a cigarette. The rain was heavy and the wind was strong.

She tried several times, but the weak flame kept being blown out by the wind.

Hearing Sally's words, she looked up and saw Liang Shi holding the umbrella.

Memory suddenly pulled back to that summer.

That day's rain was heavier than this. She had no friends and stood alone in a small alley trying to light a cigarette.

Just like today.

Before long, someone came over, also holding a black umbrella, and brushed past her.

That face was very beautiful, beautiful to the point of being unforgettable at first sight.

But what attracted Zhou Yi'an wasn't that face.

It was the hostility and restless agitation in those eyes.

It was the feeling of scoundrels finding their own kind.

It was the magnetic attraction between bad kids.

She looked at that person's back with interest, then smiled with curved lips.

The other person turned back, looking at her with those eyes full of hostility, "What the hell are you laughing at?"

She laughed even louder, "Laughing at you, sister."

The other person looked over contemptuously, "Crazy."

Unlike all the other looks of disgust and fear that people gave her, when she looked at Zhou Yi'an, there was also intense interest.

It's just that all that interest was hidden beneath the hostility.

"Put on your jacket." That voice overlapping with the past rang out, but it no longer had the arrogance and hostility of before, only gentleness remained, like a cup of plain boiled water.

Zhou Yi'an pressed the lighter again, and the flame briefly lit up, but was blown out by the wind before it could light the cigarette.

In the distance, Liang Shi put away the umbrella and helped Xu Qingzhu put on her jacket, truly being considerate in every way.

Zhou Yi'an suddenly threw the lighter in her hand toward them.

With a loud snap, it was extremely loud.

Everyone looked over.

Liang Shi frowned with an impatient expression, but those eyes no longer had what she had once seen and been crazy about—badness.

How had it changed?

Zhou Yi'an sneered coldly.

She was wearing a gray hoodie and couldn't be bothered to look anymore. She put the hood up, revealing a slightly mischievous smile, then turned and walked away with large strides.

Sally, who had been startled, belatedly cursed: "Fuck!"

"Is she crazy?" Liang Shi bent down to pick up that discarded lighter and throw it in the trash, then changed her tone to ask Sally: "How are you getting back? Should I give you a ride?"

Lin Luoxi said: "I didn't drive. I'll take this drunk, you just take Zhu Zi² home."

"Okay, be careful on the road." Liang Shi instructed.

After parting with Sally and the others, Liang Shi also carefully instructed the employees who had come to the dinner together, watching them all take taxis home before taking Xu Qingzhu to the car.

Xu Qingzhu had been silently observing her behavior. Only after she hailed a car to send the last Omega employee who had been drinking safely away did she speak up: "Liang Shi, aren't you tired?"

Liang Shi: "Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu's voice was light and airy, as if it could scatter in the wind at any moment, "Being so considerate in every way, doing so many things to please me, taking care of everyone—aren't you tired?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Actually, she was a little tired.

But Liang Shi felt that she wasn't doing these things to please Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu's understanding had a misunderstanding.

She paused and replied gently: "I'm okay. Ensuring everyone's safety after a dinner party is very important."

Xu Qingzhu quietly listened to her speak.

"I'm not being considerate in every way to please you, I'm just doing what I should do." Liang Shi said: "You're drunk, it's a rainy day, I just finished sending my colleague's child home, then came to pick you up. This isn't pleasing you."

Liang Shi paused and suddenly laughed lightly, "Xu Qingzhu, if this counts, then you're too easily pleased. These are all small matters."

Liang Shi didn't take these things to heart; to her they were just simple acts.

Just like sending Xu Qingzhu's colleagues home—for her it was just a few words, but it could potentially save a life.

Xu Qingzhu was shocked by her phrase "these are all small matters."

Because she had always believed that character was revealed in the details.

And she didn't quite trust Liang Shi's character.

A person might be able to act—act kind, smart, act so convincingly it seemed real, but just like a crime scene would always leave traces of the criminal.

Fake would always be fake, and acting would definitely be exposed one day.

But Liang Shi's actions today had somehow touched the soft spot in her heart.

After getting in the car, she saw Ling Dang.

Ling Dang politely greeted her, "Hello, Aunt."

"Hello there." Xu Qingzhu greeted her back.

After that, Ling Dang became absorbed in watching cartoons and didn't talk anymore.

Xu Qingzhu's mind was also in chaos. She was thinking—could a person really change completely?

This question had appeared in her mind countless times, but had also been denied by her countless times.

But tonight, she wavered.

Footnotes:

¹ **wuwuwu**: An onomatopoeia representing crying sounds, commonly used in Chinese internet slang to express being emotionally moved or overwhelmed.

² **Zhu Zi**: An affectionate nickname for Xu Qingzhu. "Zhu" (竹) means bamboo, and "zi" (子) is a diminutive suffix, so it's like calling her "Little Bamboo."

³ **CP-shipping**: "CP" stands for "couple pairing" and refers to fans romantically pairing up characters or real people. This is a very popular activity in Chinese fandom culture.

⁴ **White-lotus-turned-dark**: A character archetype in Chinese web novels. "White lotus" (白蓮花) refers to someone who appears pure and innocent on the surface, while "turned dark" (黑化) means they reveal their true manipulative or villainous nature.

⁵ **Little animal in a melon field**: This is a reference to a famous line from Lu Xun's story "My Old Home" about a creature called "獾" (cha) that steals melons. Here it's used metaphorically to describe someone following gossip trails.

Chapter 40-7

//

In the evening, Ling Dang insisted on sleeping with them, so while Ling Dang was watching TV, the two briefly discussed and Xu Qingzhu went upstairs to change the bedding to a double-sized comforter, while Liang Shi secretly moved her own pillow upstairs.

Before sleeping, Ling Dang even made a video call to her parents.

At that time, Liang Shi was sitting at the head of the bed reading a book, while Xu Qingzhu was washing up in the bathroom.

Liang Shi chatted with Sun Meirou for a while, mainly reporting on Ling Dang's behavior today.

The summary: extremely well-behaved.

Hearing this evaluation, Ling Dang happily bounced on the bed several times.

After Xu Qingzhu came back, Ling Dang insisted on snuggling over to be held by her, saying that Aunt had a sweet fragrance and was soft and fluffy.

Liang Shi: "...?"

Had children become this smooth already?

After turning off the room lights, Ling Dang nestled in Xu Qingzhu's arms acting spoiled, "Aunt, will you tell me a story?"

Xu Qingzhu had drunk a little and was somewhat drowsy at the moment. Especially with a soft little girl in her arms, her hand fell on her back patting gently, and she even acted spoiled back to the child, "Let your auntie tell it."

The little child turned her gaze to Liang Shi.

Liang Shi had no choice but to start telling the story of Cinderella.

A few seconds later, Ling Dang said: "Auntie, come a little closer! It's cold today."

Liang Shi reluctantly moved closer, but afraid of bumping into Xu Qingzhu, she still kept some distance.

"Come closer." Ling Dang was unsatisfied, "Hug me!"

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu opened her eyes and met Liang Shi's embarrassed gaze, but with a mischievous smile in her eyes.

Liang Shi: "..."

She had no choice but to move closer.

Liang Shi's pleasant and soothing broadcasting voice¹ rang out in the quiet space. Before long, both Xu Qingzhu and Ling Dang fell asleep.

Only then did she breathe a sigh of relief and slowly move her hand away from Xu Qingzhu's waist.

But before she could move far, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said in a low voice: "Just sleep like this."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Xu Qingzhu's voice was very calm, but if you listened carefully, the ending tone was trembling.

She said: "Ling Dang will be cold."

//

The next morning, surprisingly, the little child was the first to wake up.

Although the energetic little child had woken up, seeing that the two adults were still sleeping, she opened her round eyes and looked left and right.

Xu Qingzhu woke up next, greeting Ling Dang with a hoarse voice, "Good morning, baby."

Ling Dang leaned over and gave her a kiss on the face.

Xu Qingzhu's heart felt as soft as cotton candy.

She hugged Ling Dang again and continued to doze.

Liang Shi also woke up soon after.

So one big and one small person greeted her in unison.

"Good morning, Liang Shi."

"Good morning, Auntie."

Liang Shi: "..."

That startled her.

Used to sleeping alone, waking up to an empty bed, suddenly having this happen made Liang Shi confused for several seconds.

But then she buried her head in the blanket and laughed quietly to herself.

Ling Dang also leaned over and gave her a kiss on the face.

Liang Shi suddenly asked Xu Qingzhu: "Do you have any plans today?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Rest."

Liang Shi said excitedly: "Then let me celebrate for you! Congratulations on successfully holding your new product launch!"

Xu Qingzhu: "Hmm? What are we going to eat?"

Liang Shi: "...Make crafts!"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She held back and didn't ask: What's the logical connection here?

Probably has that serious illness².

Footnotes:

¹ **Broadcasting voice:** Refers to the clear, precise pronunciation and speech patterns used by professional radio and television announcers in China, characterized by perfect articulation and proper tone.

² **Has that serious illness:** A humorous Chinese internet slang expression (有那个大病) used to jokingly suggest someone is being illogical or silly, similar to saying "something's wrong with their brain" in a playful way.

Chapter 40-8

//

Liang Shi found a ceramic craft shop on the fifth floor of a shopping mall. After making ceramics here, they could take them home. It supported activities for 1-4 people.

Originally, she had only planned for two people to come, but today they also brought a little child.

Ling Dang had never been to such a place and found everything novel.

After entering, she took the lead in choosing the shape she wanted to make.

The process of making ceramics was a bit like playing with mud. Liang Shi didn't experience the joy of childhood, but instead, because she hadn't completed the last additional task, she worried that something might go wrong again this time, so she kept watching Xu Qingzhu's phone, afraid that someone would call her away again.

The whole process was nerve-wracking.

Most importantly, she had no more chances.

If she didn't complete this task, she would definitely have to accept a misfortune system punishment before accumulating to eighty points and before the next passive task was refreshed.

Xu Qingzhu and Ling Dang played quite well together.

Both were the type with skillful hands, so the simple version of ceramics wasn't difficult for them.

After finishing, the teacher would take them for firing, and they would come back to collect them when the time came.

Seeing that there was still time, the group went to the gaming area on the third floor.

Ling Dang was indeed a serious claw machine¹ enthusiast. She played nearly a hundred coins and caught... three dolls.

Later, it was Liang Shi who mastered the claw machine patterns and managed to catch them efficiently when there weren't many coins left.

But it was enough for Ling Dang to play with.

After catching enough for Ling Dang, Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu, "Do you want one?"

Xu Qingzhu's gaze drifted to the claw machine next door, staring at the relatively large Doraemon².

Liang Shi: "..."

She coughed lightly, "I think it would be more cost-effective for us to buy a new one, don't you think?"

Xu Qingzhu said seriously, "I think so too."

So they unanimously headed to the toy store and bought a big Doraemon.

Ling Dang looked at the small toy in her hands: "..."

Suddenly it wasn't appealing anymore.

When the time came, they went to collect the fired ceramics and decided to go eat on the top floor of the mall.

But on the way to the elevator area, Xu Qingzhu suddenly tugged at Liang Shi's sleeve.

Liang Shi asked: "What's wrong?"

"Over there." Xu Qingzhu pointed in a direction. Liang Shi looked in that direction and saw Mrs. Qi and—Qi Jiao.

"Mrs. Qi." Xu Qingzhu said: "That woman who was inexplicably strange last time."

Liang Shi frowned, thinking about the relationship between those two people.

Mrs. Qi and Qi Jiao walked side by side. Qi Jiao's expression was timid and cowering, looking like a soulless puppet with the strings controlling her held in Mrs. Qi's hands.

Mrs. Qi was as always, dressed in designer brands, wearing a water-blue qipao³ that looked out of place in this modern building.

Mrs. Qi, Jiaojiao, Qi Jiao—

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Do you think that's the Jiaojiao she mentioned?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes."

"How do you know?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised.

"That's my colleague's child's teacher." Liang Shi said: "Her name is Qi Jiao."

"Do she and I look alike?" Xu Qingzhu was puzzled, "We're obviously very different."

"Not alike." Liang Shi said.

Ling Dang suddenly said: "Eh? Isn't that Grandma Qi?"

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu both crouched down at the same time, "You know her?"

Ling Dang nodded, "She often comes to our house to play mahjong⁴ with Grandma. Aunt Qi Jiao also comes often."

"Has she ever hit you?" Liang Shi immediately asked.

For some reason, after seeing Mrs. Qi, she felt an inexplicable sense of oppression in her heart.

She always felt that the scene from that night would repeat itself.

In that dark small room, she was being disciplined and beaten.

And the little child with her didn't even dare to cry.

Just thinking about it made her feel like she couldn't breathe.

She was afraid that Ling Dang had also suffered such things.

Ling Dang shook her head, "Why would she hit me? My mom would never let her hit me."

Liang Shi: "..."

She felt inexplicably stabbed.

Liang Shi asked again: "Does she have any strange behaviors?"

"Not really." Ling Dang said, then suddenly paused, "Does it count that she often hits Aunt Qi Jiao?"

Ling Dang was afraid of being overheard, so she lowered her voice extremely low, leaning between the two of them to whisper, "Last time I saw Aunt Qi Jiao's body was covered in pinch marks, and whenever Grandma Qi gets unhappy, she slaps Aunt Qi Jiao. And once, when I went in to play with Grandma, Aunt Qi Jiao was kneeling on a nail board."

"Nail board?!" Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu gasped.

"Not the sharp side." Ling Dang said: "Just the flat side, with several rows of nails. Aunt Qi Jiao's face was completely pale, and her tears reached here."

She even demonstrated as she spoke, "But Grandma Qi wouldn't let her cry, saying that if tears fell, she would flip the nail board over and make her kneel on it."

Liang Shi & Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Ah, this.

Ling Dang continued: "But Grandma Qi also often has wounds on her body. She's come to our house several times with bruises on her face."

Liang Shi: "..."

Ling Dang glanced at Xu Qingzhu, then secretly crawled to Liang Shi's ear to whisper, "Auntie, you also need to be careful of Grandma Qi."

"Why?" Liang Shi asked.

"Last time when Aunt Qi Jiao was kneeling on the nail board, Grandma Qi said she would keep that thing at our house." Ling Dang swallowed nervously but still continued: "She said if you don't behave, she'll have Grandma make you kneel on that nail board."

Liang Shi: "..."

Are these people crazy?

Ling Dang sighed, "I've had nightmares about that for several nights."

But she was like a little adult, "I had Grandma throw that thing away, so don't be afraid, no one will bully you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her emotions suddenly reached a critical point, and tears suddenly fell, as if this sentence had crossed twenty years, with Ling Dang comforting that little child from back then.

She said—don't be afraid, no one will bully you.

Liang Shi's heart was inexplicably touched.

Xu Qingzhu handed her tissues.

A moment later, learning from Ling Dang's example, she reached out and patted Liang Shi's shoulder: "Don't worry, I'll protect you from now on. No one will bully you."

Footnotes:

¹ **Claw machine:** Also known as crane games or UFO catchers, these are arcade games where players use a mechanical claw to try to grab prizes, very popular in Asia.

² **Doraemon:** A famous Japanese manga and anime character - a blue robotic cat from the future. Very popular throughout Asia as both entertainment and merchandise.

³ **Qipao:** A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, characterized by a high collar, fitted silhouette, and side slits.

⁴ **Mahjong:** A traditional Chinese tile-based game commonly played by four people, very popular among middle-aged and elderly people in China as a social activity.